PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #61 · ABUSE

“What was done to me was my fault. I must have caused it.”

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Where it often comes from

People who were harmed often hunt for a reason they could have controlled. “If it was my fault, I can keep it from happening again.” That search feels like safety. It is a lie that adds shame to harm. What was done to you was someone else’s choice or someone else’s failure to protect you. You did not cause it by existing, by trusting, or by being unable to stop it. You do not have to describe it in order to lay this sentence down. If you are not safe right now, call 911. You can also call the National Domestic Violence Hotline at 1-800-799-7233. If a child is being hurt, call Childhelp at 1-800-422-4453. A counselor can help you at a pace that is safe. You do not have to do this alone, or all at once.

What Scripture teaches

There is no condemnation in Christ for the person who was hurt and then blamed themselves. The Lord has compassion and knows our frame. He is near the brokenhearted. He binds up the brokenhearted and proclaims liberty. Jesus says not to let your heart be troubled. None of these verses say that suffering proves you caused it. Wanting to have stopped it is grief. It is not a verdict.

> *“Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus”* (Romans 8:1).

Also see

> “As a father has compassion on his children, so the LORD has compassion on those who fear Him. For He knows our frame; He is mindful that we are dust” (Psalm 103:13–14).

> “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit” (Psalm 34:18).

> “The Spirit of the Lord GOD is on Me, because the LORD has anointed Me to preach good news to the poor. He has sent Me to bind up the brokenhearted, to proclaim liberty to the captives and freedom to the prisoners” (Isaiah 61:1).

> “Peace I leave with you; My peace I give to you. I do not give to you as the world gives. Do not let your hearts be troubled; do not be afraid” (John 14:27).

Common self-statements

- I must have done something to make it happen.
- If I had been different, it would not have happened.
- A better person would have prevented it.
- I do not deserve comfort because I let it happen.
- God agrees that it was my fault.
- If I stop blaming myself, I will not be safe.

Common logical errors

- Personalization: Taking the blame for what another person did.
- Hindsight bias: Judging your past self with facts you did not have then.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling guilty and deciding the feeling is proof.
- All-or-nothing thinking: If you did not stop it perfectly, it was entirely your fault.

Challenging questions

- What do I believe I should have done, and could I really have done it then?
- Whose choice was it, if I set my self-blame aside?
- Would I say this was a friend's fault if it had happened to them?
- Am I using blame to feel less helpless?
- What does "no condemnation" mean for a person who was hurt?
- What would my counselor want me to stop saying to myself?

Truth summary

> What was done to me was not my fault. I did not cause it, and I do not have to carry blame that belongs to someone else.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

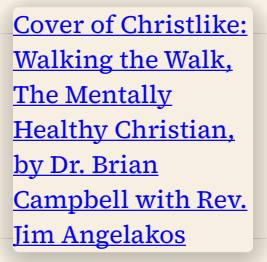
- Guilt/Shame
- Thinking, Healthy
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Love, By God
- Forgiveness

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Thinking, Healthy
- Suffering
- Self-Esteem, Low

What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from "The Mentally Healthy Christian" (with every Scripture written out)

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Dear Younger Me — MercyMe
God meets the younger you with kindness, not with the blame you have been carrying.

Clean — Natalie Grant
Shame after harm is not the same thing as being the cause of it.

The Power of the Cross — Keith and Kristyn Getty
Christ carries guilt that is truly yours. He does not ask you to carry someone else's.

To God Be the Glory — Reawaken Hymns
God's glory is mercy, not a trial of the person who was hurt.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"

My Plan for Replacing "What was done to me was my fault. I must have caused it."

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"What was done to me was my fault. I must have caused it." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What do I believe I should have done, and could I really have done it then?
- ☐ Whose choice was it, if I set my self-blame aside?
- ☐ Would I say this was a friend's fault if it had happened to them?
- ☐ Am I using blame to feel less helpless?
- ☐ What does "no condemnation" mean for a person who was hurt?
- ☐ What would my counselor want me to stop saying to myself?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ What was done to me was not my fault. I did not cause it, and I do not have to carry blame that belongs to someone else.
- ☐ I did not cause what was done to me.
- ☐ Wanting to have stopped it is not the same as causing it.
- ☐ I am not on trial for someone else's choice.
- ☐ God is near me. He is not accusing me.
- ☐ I can grieve without agreeing with the blame.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Romans 8:1
  "Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus."
- ☐ Psalm 103:13–14
  "As a father has compassion on his children, so the LORD has compassion on those who fear Him. For He knows our frame; He is mindful that we are dust."
- ☐ Psalm 34:18
  "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] When you blamed yourself: Each day, write down one moment when you took the fault for what was done to you. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Romans 8:1 becomes: "Sarah can write: "What was done to me was not my fault. In Christ I am not condemned.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Guilt/Shame" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio or the Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone. If you are not safe right now, call 911 or 1-800-799-7233.

- [ ] Write the charge, then a fair sentence. One line of self-blame. Then one line you would say to a friend. No graphic detail.
- [ ] Ask your counselor to help you separate grief from blame. Stop if it becomes too much.
- [ ] Refuse one "I caused it." When the sentence starts, say, "That was not mine to cause," and stop.
- [ ] Read Romans 8:1 each morning before you review the past.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "What was done to me was my fault. I must have caused it.": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A moment I did not take the blame
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~What was done to me was my fault. I must have caused it~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have blamed myself for harm I did not choose. There is no condemnation in Christ. Teach me the difference between grief and guilt, and give me a safe counselor as I lay this down. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.